

11,775
No. of pilots presently employed by various airlines in India

22,400
Pilots needed to fly an estimated 1,400-strong fleet by 2029

2,375
The likely shortfall in the next five years*

*If the DGCA keeps issuing 1,650 commercial pilot licences annually and other factors remain constant

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A GROWING FLEET

India currently has an 800-plus fleet with 1,147 more aircraft scheduled for delivery to just three airlines by 2030. Their combined order since 2015: 1,976 new planes

■ Aircraft ordered since 2015 **()** Present pilot strength

Air India Group	IndiGo	Akasa Air
470	1,280	226
(5,380*)	(5,174)	(849)

*includes Air India, Air India Express and Alliance Air

CAPA India, when the country's total requirement will be 19,400 pilots. But going by the ministry's estimates for India's fleet size and the industry's staffing norms, the country could very well require as many as 22,400 pilots by 2029. Given the present strength of 11,775 pilots and assuming that the DGCA keeps issuing around 1,650 CPLs each year—1,622 were issued in 2023, up from 744 in 2019—India is looking at a shortfall of about 2,375 pilots in the next five years. And that's a conservative estimate. Nothing stops the airlines from ordering more planes or the manufacturers from speeding up the deliveries. For instance, Air India CEO Campbell Wilson has recently revealed the plan to take delivery of one aircraft every six days. That is over 50 new ones within a year just for Air India.

But that is not all. "To create more pilots, the country needs more pilot training institutes. And the existing ones need to expand their fleet and employ more pilots as trainers," says Hemanth D.P., CEO of Asia Pacific Flight Training Academy. "And if you include these flight training schools and the entire gamut of commercial aviation, like chartered services and cargo,